

C2 Reading

New Generation English · Academic diagnostic

Reading

Proficiency, judgement and the problem of excessive language

At the highest levels, language proficiency is rarely a matter of knowing more grammar in a simple quantitative sense. The learner's challenge becomes rhetorical: choosing how direct to be, deciding which implication can be left unstated, recognising when precision becomes pedantry, and when fluency begins to conceal vagueness. A speaker may produce complex sentences and still fail to sound intellectually controlled if every idea is overstated or every qualification is treated as a decorative flourish.

This is why advanced diagnostics should not merely ask whether a structure is correct. Correctness remains necessary, but it is no longer sufficient. The stronger question is whether the language is proportionate to the situation. A complaint to an institution, an academic response, a seminar intervention and a personal reflection may all require accurate grammar, yet they demand different degrees of compression, tact and explicitness. The advanced learner must therefore demonstrate not just range, but restraint.

Task design can distort this judgement. A simplistic prompt may reward speed while concealing weak interpretation; an excessively academic prompt may reward familiarity with a genre rather than genuine control. A responsible C2 diagnostic uses several lenses: dense reading, layered listening, extended writing, spontaneous speaking and grammar items that test judgement as well as form. It should ask not only whether an answer is correct, but whether it is purposeful, responsive to context and stylistically mature.

The best feedback at this level sounds less like a verdict and more like an editorial conversation. It notices when complexity becomes ornament, when

caution becomes evasion, and when fluency loses precision. It does not punish ambition, but it asks the learner to choose. At C2, excellence is often the capacity to use less language more exactly.

Questions

1. What is the main claim about highest-level proficiency?

- A. It depends on rhetorical judgement, not just more grammar.
- B. It is mainly vocabulary quantity.
- C. It removes the need for accuracy.

Answer: _____

2. When can fluency become a problem?

- A. When it conceals vagueness.
- B. When it is too slow.
- C. When it uses simple words.

Answer: _____

3. Why is correctness insufficient?

- A. Different contexts require different rhetorical choices.
- B. Correctness is irrelevant.
- C. Grammar cannot be assessed.

Answer: _____

4. What does proportionate language mean?

- A. Language suited to situation and purpose.
- B. The longest possible answer.
- C. Language without nuance.

Answer: _____

5. What can a simplistic prompt conceal?

- A. Weak interpretation.
- B. Excellent handwriting.
- C. Fast reading only.

Answer: _____

6. What risk does an excessively academic prompt create?

- A. It may reward genre familiarity rather than control.
- B. It makes grammar impossible.
- C. It removes vocabulary.

Answer: _____

7. What should C2 grammar items test?

- A. Judgement as well as form.
- B. Only spelling.
- C. Only speed.

Answer: _____

8. What does editorial conversation imply?

- A. Precise developmental feedback.
- B. A final punishment.
- C. A casual chat without standards.

Answer: _____

9. What does complexity becomes ornament mean?

- A. Complex language used decoratively rather than purposefully.
- B. All complex language is wrong.
- C. Ornament improves clarity.

Answer: _____

10. What is excellence at C2 often described as?

- A. Using less language more exactly.
- B. Speaking as fast as possible.
- C. Avoiding all risk.

Answer: _____